China Entry Checklist (US passport)

EARNED ESCAPE

Rules change; verify with NIA and your airline before you fly.
Last checked: October 18, 2026
Tick each box. The link after each item is where I checked it.

1. Pick your entry route

I've done both: the 240-hour transit in August 2026 and a tourist visa in January 2026.

- ☐ **240-hour visa-free transit, or tourist visa?** US passports are **not** on China's 30-day visa-free list. The only visa-free option is the 240-hour transit with an onward ticket to a third country or region. Otherwise you need a tourist visa. NIA 30-day list | State Dept
- ☐ **Using the 240-hour transit, all of these are true:** NIA, Visa-Free Transit Policies
  - ☐ Ordinary US passport.
  - ☐ Onward ticket **to a third country or region**, with a confirmed seat and departure date. US to China to US does not qualify. Hong Kong, Macao and Taiwan count as onward destinations, but the onward place must differ from where you came from. MTR High Speed Rail
  - ☐ Arriving through one of the 65 designated ports (for example Beijing Capital, Beijing Daxing, Shanghai Pudong, Shanghai Hongqiao, Xi'an Xianyang, Chongqing Jiangbei, Chengdu Shuangliu, Chengdu Tianfu). Check your exact port in NIA's table.
  - ☐ Whole stay inside the permitted areas, 10 days maximum, counted from midnight after your arrival day. Beijing government FAQ
  - ☐ Trip is tourism, business, visits or family. No work, study or news reporting.
  - ☐ Unusual routing? Call NIA's hotline, +86 12367, before you book.
- ☐ **Using a tourist visa (L visa):** for trips over 10 days or a round trip to and from the US. Most US citizens may apply for a 10-year multiple-entry tourist visa. State Dept
  - ☐ Apply online in COVA (consular.mfa.gov.cn/VISA) to the Chinese Embassy or Consulate-General that covers your state. Chinese Embassy, COVA guidelines
  - ☐ Apply within 90 days of your entry date. COVA does not accept earlier applications. Chinese Embassy, COVA guidelines
  - ☐ Upload: passport bio page and a blank visa page, proof of US residence (driver's license, utility bill or bank bill), and your latest Chinese visa if you have one. No ticket, hotel, itinerary or invitation letter needed for US tourist applicants since January 1, 2024. Chinese Embassy, requirements
  - ☐ When the status reads "Passport to be submitted," you or an agent hand in your passport and the barcode page at the visa office. Regular processing averages 4 business days, express 3, from passport submission. Check the Embassy's fee page for current fees. Chinese Embassy, requirements
  - ☐ The name on your visa must match your passport exactly. State Dept

2. Passport and documents

- ☐ Passport valid at least 6 months beyond your arrival date, with at least 2 blank pages. A US emergency passport is not accepted for visa-free entry. State Dept
- ☐ Printed copies of your onward ticket and hotel bookings. Beijing's government FAQ recommends carrying tickets and accommodation reservations as proof of your trip purpose. Beijing FAO FAQ
- ☐ Dual US and Chinese nationals: the State Department strongly encourages entering on your US passport with a Chinese visa. Read its dual-nationality section first. State Dept
- ☐ Traveling with a child and one parent: bring the child's birth certificate and a notarized consent letter from the absent parent. State Dept

3. Before you leave home

- ☐ Read the current State Department advisory for China (Level 2, Exercise increased caution, issued September 4, 2026) and enroll in STEP. State Dept
- ☐ Buy travel insurance that covers medical care and evacuation abroad. Most US health plans don't, and Chinese hospitals ask for payment up front. State Dept
- ☐ Prescriptions in original packaging with your doctor's prescription. Check ADHD medications (for example Adderall, Vyvanse) and epinephrine with the Chinese Embassy before you pack. State Dept
- ☐ Check every bag for ammunition, casings or parts, even empty ones. State Dept
- ☐ Cash: no more than RMB 20,000 on entry or exit. State Dept

4. Payments (set up and test at home)

- ☐ **Alipay:** download, sign up, choose the International Version, add a Visa, Mastercard, JCB, Discover or Diners Club card. No Chinese bank account or phone number needed. Foreign cards can't send money to people. Alipay+ | Ant Group
- ☐ **WeChat Pay:** Me > Pay and Services > Wallet > Bank Cards > Add a Bank Card. Verify with your passport. Your US number works if it receives SMS. No fee on single payments under 200 RMB; 3% above. WeChat Help Center
- ☐ Carry some cash in small bills as a backup. Vendors must accept cash, but some can't make change. Credit cards work mainly at large international stores and hotels. State Dept
- ☐ Know that these apps may share data with Chinese authorities. State Dept

5. Phone and data

- ☐ Add your carrier's international plan for China before you fly (Verizon, for example, lists China on TravelPass). Check your own carrier's current list and price. Verizon TravelPass countries
- ☐ Update your phone and apps before you leave. Consider a travel phone with no sensitive data. State Dept
- ☐ No VPN: the State Department says VPN use in China is illegal in most cases. Avoid public Wi-Fi. State Dept
- ☐ Expect most popular US social apps to be blocked. State Dept

6. Arrival

- ☐ Fill in your arrival card online, free, only at the official site s.nia.gov.cn/ArrivalCardFillingPC or in the NIA 12367 app. NIA warns about fake sites that charge a fee. You can also do it at the port. NIA
- ☐ 240-hour transit: tell the officer at the port you are applying for visa-free transit and show your onward ticket. Approval is decided on site. Allow extra time. Beijing government FAQ | MTR

7. While you're there

- ☐ Hotels register you automatically. Staying anywhere else? You or your host must register within 24 hours, online in NIA 12367 or at the local police station, and again at each new place. NIA | State Dept
- ☐ Carry your passport at all times. Hotels, trains and police may check it. State Dept
- ☐ Trains: register on China Railway's English 12306 site with your passport and finish the real-name check before you travel. I rode high-speed rail business class Xi'an to Chongqing in January and Chongqing to Chengdu in August; at main stations it includes a waiting lounge and staff guidance. China Railway service 12306 register | 12306 FAQ
- ☐ 240-hour transit: leave China on your confirmed onward ticket within the 10 days. Do not overstay. NIA
- ☐ Emergency numbers: 110 police, 120 ambulance, 119 fire. US Embassy Beijing: +86 10 8531 4000. State Dept

Want help building the trip around this? Plan it with me at **earnedescape.agency/plan**.
Earned Escape is run by Chuck (Charles Betancourt), Independent Advisor, an affiliate of Castle Dreams Travel.